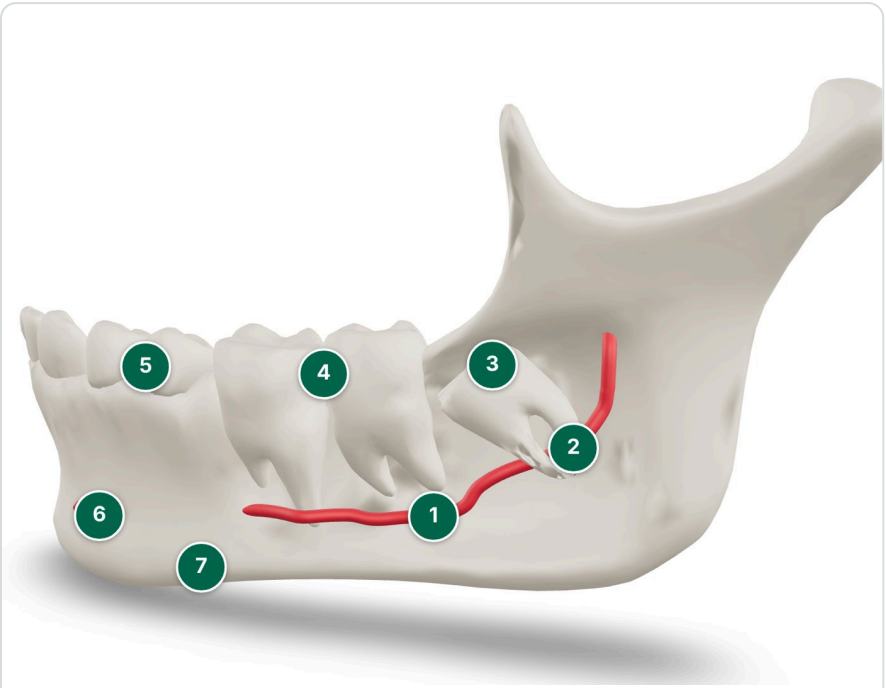
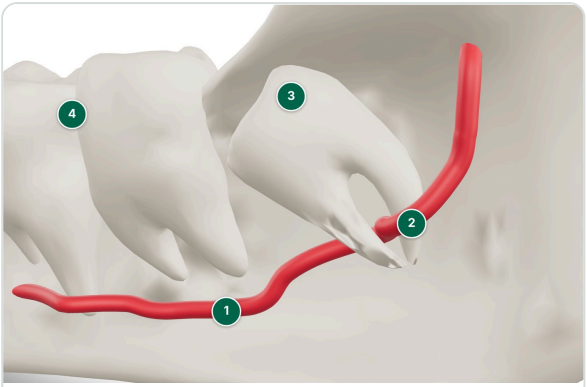
Impacted lower wisdom tooth and the nerve near it

The roots of this wisdom tooth wrap around a nerve. Taking the tooth out can damage the nerve and make your lip and chin numb.



Whole jaw (cheek side)

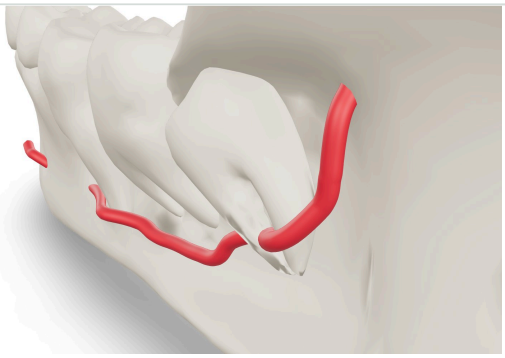


Roots and nerve (close-up)

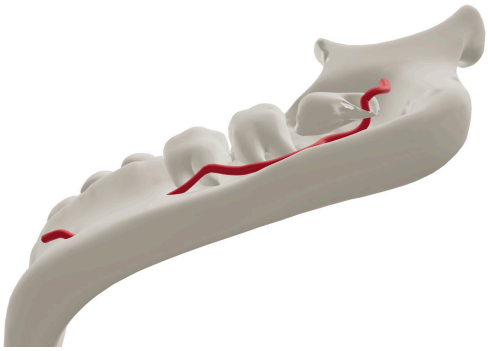
- Jaw bone and teeth
- Nerve, artery and vein (in their canal)

Parts of the model

1. Jaw nerve (inferior alveolar nerve)
2. Roots of the wisdom tooth
3. Wisdom tooth (third molar)
4. First and second molars
5. First and second premolars
6. Chin nerve (mental nerve)
7. Jaw bone (mandible)



Roots around the nerve, from behind



The nerve in the jaw, from below

What is the problem?

Your wisdom teeth (**third molars**) are the last teeth at the back. An **impacted lower wisdom tooth** is stuck under the gum and bone. It has not come through the gum (it is **unerupted**). It cannot grow in the right way.

The nerve

A nerve runs in a tube of bone inside your lower jaw. Here we call it the **jaw nerve**. Its medical name is the **inferior alveolar nerve**. Two blood vessels run with it in the same tube. They are the **inferior alveolar artery and vein**.[1]

The jaw nerve gives feeling to your lower teeth and gums on the same side.[2] Near the front of your jaw, a branch of it comes out of the bone through a small hole. This branch is the **chin nerve** (**mental nerve**). It gives feeling to your lower lip and chin.[3]

Your tongue gets its feeling from a different nerve (the **lingual nerve**). Taking out a wisdom tooth can also hurt this nerve.[4] Lasting damage to it is rare. It happens to about 1 to 3 in 1,000 people.[5] This model does not show the tongue nerve.

In this model, **the roots of the wisdom tooth wrap around the nerve and artery**.

Why taking the tooth out can hurt the nerve

To take the tooth out, the surgeon must lift the roots out of the bone. The roots curve around the nerve. So the roots can press, stretch or cut the nerve as they come out. The artery and vein can also tear and bleed.[1]

The chin nerve branches off the jaw nerve. So damage to the jaw nerve can also stop the chin nerve working well.[3]

What nerve damage feels like

Your lower lip, chin, teeth or gums on that side may:[2,4]

- feel numb
- feel strange
- tingle
- hurt

Short-term: the feeling comes back, most often within weeks to months. **Long-term:** the feeling does not fully come back.[2]

The older you are, the higher the risk, and the less likely the feeling is to come back fully.[2,6]

How often does it happen?

Some wisdom teeth have roots close to the nerve. A review of 16 studies looked at these teeth. Rates vary, but for these teeth:[7]

About 7 in 100
may get nerve damage after the whole tooth is taken out

About 1 in 100
may have nerve damage that does not go away

Sources **0.** Juodzbalys G, Wang HL, Sabalys G. J Oral Maxillofac Res. 2010;1(1):e2. doi.org/10.5037/jomr.2010.1102 **0.** Sarikov R, Juodzbalys G. J Oral Maxillofac Res. 2014;5(4):e1. doi.org/10.5037/jomr.2014.5401 **0.** Juodzbalys G, Wang HL, Sabalys G. J Oral Maxillofac Res. 2010;1(1):e3. doi.org/10.5037/jomr.2010.1103 **0.** Renton T, Yilmaz Z. J Orofac Pain. 2011;25(4):333-344. PMID 22247929. pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/22247929 **0.** Lee J, Feng B, Park JS, et al. PLoS One. 2023;18(2):e0282185. doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0282185 **0.** Queral-Godoy E, Valmaseda-Castellón E, Berini-Aytés L, et al. Oral Surg Oral Med Oral Pathol Oral Radiol Endod. 2005;99(3):259-264. doi.org/10.1016/j.tripleo.2004.06.001 **0.** Rico-Barroso L, Barroso-Medel M, Gutiérrez-Pérez J, et al. Med Oral Patol Oral Cir Bucal. 2026;31(1):e19-e30. doi.org/10.4317/medoral.27459

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